

Commonly misused words

SOME GRAMMATICAL ERRORS OCCUR FREQUENTLY.

It's common to make grammatical mistakes when speaking, but when these mistakes are transferred to writing, the meaning of a sentence is often affected. Most of these problems result from confusion between two words.

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That or which?

Use *that* for restrictive relative clauses, which introduce essential information, and *which* for nonrestrictive relative clauses, which introduce additional, nonessential information.



The cats **that** are black are sleeping.



The cats, **which** are black, are sleeping.

May or might?

The auxiliary verb *may* implies a possibility that something will happen, while *might* indicates a real uncertainty. If something is unlikely to happen, use *might*.

I **may** go for a swim later.

You **might** encounter a shark.

Can or may?

Can refers to a person's ability to do something, whereas *may* is used to ask permission. These auxiliary verbs are not interchangeable.

Can you cook?

May I come?

I or me?

The simplest way to know which pronoun to use is to remove the other person from the sentence. It should then become obvious. Always remember to put the other person or people first.

Isabella, Rosie, and I went to a café. “I went to a café” makes sense, so this is correct.

Rosie bought coffee for Isabella and me. “Rosie bought coffee for me” makes sense, so this is correct.

Who or whom?

Think of *who* as representing *he* or *she*, and *whom* as representing *him* or *her*. If in doubt, rephrase the sentence and substitute *he/she* or *him/her*.

Finn, **who** loved snow, went outside. The substituted clause would be “he loved snow.”

Finn found Greg, **whom** Finn had telephoned earlier. The substituted clause would be “Finn had telephoned him.”